



When you are shooting, very minute pushes and pulls — such as wind from the air conditioning or even the pulse in your body — can cause you to miss your target. The larger you are, the more this will affect you,” he says.

There are other such advantages, says Burger. “In the standing position, women place the elbow of their arm supporting the rifle hand-guard very close to their hip bone, if not exactly over it. They can use bone structure to hold up the gun. There’s almost a direct line from their hands to their elbow to their hips to the ground,” says Burger.

Finding the same posture is generally harder for men. “For a lot of guys, their elbow ends several inches above their hipbone. They end up using their ribcage to support their elbow,” he says.

All these advantages, Burger says, are particularly highlighted in standing events like the 10m air rifle. He doesn’t think there’s as much of an edge for women rifle shooters in

events like the 50m rifle 3 positions event. “Being taller doesn’t help when you are shooting standing up. But in positions like kneeling and prone, there’s no advantage to having longer arms,” he says.

While these arguments generally hold true, not everyone is completely convinced. “While women do have certain advantages, not every woman shooter has the same physiological advantages. Even within women, there is a lot of variation. A lot depends on the qualities of the individual shooter,” says Kim Jin-Oh, coach of the South Korean team that won gold in the women’s individual category through Ban Hyojin, who also scored the highest qualification score across men and women at the 2024 Olympics.

Recent developments in the sport — especially in the stabilising suits that men and women wear during competitions — have flattened the distinction between men and women. For the first time in many years, the current men’s world record

**Nerves of steel:** Republic of Korea’s Ban Hyojin (in pic) won gold in the 10m Air Rifle Women’s Final in Paris. She was tied with China’s Huang Yuting at 251.8, whom she beat in the final shoot-off by 0.1 point. GETTY IMAGES

in qualifying is higher than that in the women’s discipline. “The material is so strong and stiff that it makes your internal structure a little less important than it used to be,” says Burger.

At the end of the day, Jindal says, the fact that women compete in different categories than men means that any physical advantages are nullified. “I know that there are certain advantages that women have in air rifle when it comes to body shape, but at the end of the day, we compete in two different events. There’s a lot we can learn from each other. There’s a lot I do learn from my seniors, and that doesn’t matter whether they are boys or girls,” she says.